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Exploring the Effects of Technology-Mediated Job Interviews on Anxiety and Performance: A Mixed Methods Study in the Turkish Context

Teknoloji Aracılı İş Mülakatlarının Anksiyete ve Performans Üzerindeki Etkisi: Türkiye Bağlamında Bir Karma Yöntem Araştırması

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Abstract

Technology-mediated interviews have become increasingly common, yet little is known about how different formats shape candidates' anxiety and performance. Using a convergent mixed-method design, this study compared face-to-face (FTF), synchronous video interviews (SVI), and AI-led asynchronous video interviews (AVI) among emerging adults in a simulated hiring context. Quantitative results showed that higher interview anxiety predicted lower self-rated performance, whereas observer-rated performance was unaffected. Self-expression satisfaction was lower in AI-led AVIs than in SVIs. Interview format moderated the link between behavioral anxiety and observer-rated performance: higher behavioral anxiety impaired performance in FTF interviews but was associated with better performance in AI-led AVIs. Qualitative findings indicated that candidates appreciated interpersonal warmth in FTF interviews, the convenience of SVIs, and the preparation time provided in AI-led AVIs. Overall, participants reported predominantly positive emotional experiences across formats. The study highlights how different interview modalities influence candidates' reactions and offers implications for designing technologically mediated recruitment practices.

Öz

Teknoloji aracılığıyla gerçekleştirilen iş mülakatları giderek yaygınlaşmasına rağmen, farklı mülakat biçimlerinin adayların kaygı ve performansını nasıl etkilediğine dair bilgiler sınırlıdır. Bu çalışma, birleşik karma yöntem kullanarak genç yetişkinlerin katıldığı bir işe alım simülasyonunda üç mülakat formatını karşılaştırmıştır: Yüz yüze mülakat (FTF), eşzamanlı video mülakatı (SVI) ve yapay zekâ tarafından yürütülen eşzamansız video mülakatı (AVI). Nicel bulgular, mülakat kaygısı arttıkça adayların kendi performanslarını daha düşük değerlendirdiklerini, ancak gözlemcilerin verdiği performans puanlarının bu kaygıdan etkilenmediğini göstermiştir. Ayrıca adaylar, öz ifade açısından yapay zekâ destekli AVI formatını SVI'a kıyasla daha az tatmin edici bulmuştur. Mülakat formatı, davranışsal kaygı ile gözlemci değerlendirmeli performans arasındaki ilişkiyi etkilemiştir: Yüz yüze mülakatlarda yüksek davranışsal kaygı performansı düşürürken, yapay zekâ destekli AVI'larda daha iyi performansla ilişkilendirilmiştir. Nitel bulgular, adayların yüz yüze mülakatlardaki kişilerarası sıcaklığı, eşzamanlı video mülakatlarının sağladığı pratikliği ve yapay zekâ destekli AVI'ların sunduğu ek hazırlık süresini olumlu değerlendirdiklerini ortaya koymuştur. Katılımcılar genel olarak tüm formatlarda ağırlıklı olarak olumlu duygusal deneyimler bildirmiştir. Bu çalışma, mülakat yöntemlerinin aday tepkilerini nasıl şekillendirdiğini göstererek teknoloji aracılı işe alım süreçlerinin tasarımına ilişkin önemli çıkarımlar sunmaktadır.

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Keywords Face-to-face interview · synchronous video interview · asynchronous video interview · interview anxiety · interview performance · applicant reactions

Anahtar Kelimeler Yüz yüze mülakat · eşzamanlı video mülakatı · eşzamansız video mülakatı · mülakat kaygısı · mülakat performansı · aday tepkileri

Exploring the Effects of Technology-Mediated Job Interviews on Anxiety and Performance: A Mixed Methods Study in the Turkish Context

The increasing digitization of organizational practices has significantly transformed personnel selection processes over the past decade. Advancements in communication technologies, the global demand for flexible recruitment methods, and the widespread impact of the COVID-19 pandemic have accelerated the adoption of technology-mediated interview formats. Once considered peripheral, video interviews have now become central to recruitment practices, with recent data suggesting that nearly 80% of organizations incorporate them as a standard part of candidate evaluation (University of Dundee, 2023).

Building upon these advancements, the evolution of technology in the selection process has progressed gradually. Initially, job interviews were conducted via telephone, representing the most primitive form. Subsequent technological advancements introduced synchronized video interviews (SVIs) in the second phase. SVIs enabled remote interviews, facilitating visual and auditory interaction between the interviewer and the candidate through cameras and microphones (Balcerak & Wozniack, 2021). Commonly used video interview software platforms include Skype, Zoom, and Spark Hire. As SVIs gained popularity, studies compared them with traditional face-to-face (FTF) and telephone interviews (Chapman et al., 2003; Sears et al., 2013).

Furthermore, more recently, asynchronous video interviews (AVIs) have emerged as a novel recruitment method. Unlike synchronous interviews, AVIs are generally one-way, allowing candidates to record their responses to predetermined questions sent to them via the internet using text, audio, or video formats. Interviewers can then review and evaluate these recordings at their convenience and in the context that suits them best (Brenner et al., 2016). While traditional AVIs were historically passive, with no role in recruitment decision-making, recent advancements in artificial intelligence (AI) have created diversification in AVIs. This diversification includes AI-assisted AVIs, which provide recommendations based on the analysis of various cues, such as facial expressions and tone of voice. Typically, human resources professionals review these recommendations. In contrast, AI-led AVIs autonomously make recruitment decisions, determining whether a candidate proceeds to the next stage of the recruitment process, without the need for human intervention (Jaser et al., 2021).

Despite the widespread adoption of technology in selection interviews, significant questions remain unanswered for academics and HR professionals. While selection interviews are increasingly integrating advanced technologies, research in industrial and organizational psychology has not kept pace with these developments (Roth et al., 2016). Thus, there is a pressing need for systematic and comprehensive studies to address these new selection methods (Chamorro-Premuzic et al., 2016). From an I/O perspective, these recruitment methods are typically evaluated on two dimensions: their validity and candidate reactions (Moscoso et al., 2017). Understanding candidate reactions are crucial, as these perceptions significantly influence the successful integration of new employees into the organization.

Despite operational benefits, concerns remain regarding the psychological experience of candidates, particularly in terms of interview anxiety and perceived performance. Prior research indicates that candidates tend to react more favorably to FTF interviews than to digital alternatives, citing greater fairness, comfort, and interpersonal engagement (Melchers et al., 2021; Sears et al., 2013). AVIs, in particular, have been perceived as less personal and more stressful due to the absence of real-time interaction and non-verbal feedback (Lukacik et al., 2022).

Given the centrality of interviews in hiring decisions, understanding how different formats influence candidate anxiety and performance is critical. Interview anxiety—defined as a situation-specific form of social anxiety triggered by evaluative contexts—has been shown to negatively impact both self-perceived and externally assessed performance (Powell et al., 2018). However, few empirical studies have directly compared FTF, SVI, and AVI formats in terms of their psychological and behavioral effects on candidates, particularly in non-Western samples.

In this regard, Türkiye represents a particularly relevant and timely context for examining technology-mediated interviews. In recent years, Türkiye has witnessed a rapid acceleration in its digital transformation, accompanied by growing public and institutional engagement with AI. According to the Stanford University Artificial Intelligence Index Report 2025, optimism toward AI has markedly increased in Türkiye, with 70% of respondents believing that AI will bring more benefits than harm—one of the highest positivity rates among emerging economies (Stanford University, 2025). National data from the Turkish Statistical Institute further highlight this trend: the share of enterprises using AI rose from 2.7% in 2021 to 7.5% in 2025, with adoption particularly prominent in information and communication sectors (Turkish Statistical Institute [TÜİK], 2025). Similarly, global surveys by Ipsos show above-average familiarity with and trust in AI among Turkish citizens, particularly younger and more digitally literate groups (Ipsos, 2025). Taken together, these indicators suggest that Türkiye's sociotechnical environment—marked by rapid digitalization, youthful technological engagement, and rising trust in AI—provides a distinctive backdrop for studying candidate experiences in AI-led interview contexts. Complementing this picture, evidence from HR professionals in Türkiye indicates that AVIs are gaining traction for efficiency and reach, yet raise candidate experience and fairness concerns when real-time interaction and feedback are limited, especially in SME-dominated labor markets with uneven digital access and literacy (İlhan et al., 2025). These context-specific opportunities and constraints make Türkiye a salient case for testing how interview format conditions the anxiety–performance link. Accordingly, our mixed-methods experiment directly compares FTF, SVI, and AI-led AVI (with candidates explicitly told that AI would score their responses) in a Turkish sample.

By addressing these gaps, the present study contributes to the literature in several important ways. First, it extends previous work by comparing candidate anxiety and performance across traditional and technology-mediated formats (FTF, SVI, and AI-led AVI) within a non-Western, Turkish-speaking sample — a context largely overlooked in the current literature. Second, by adopting a mixed-methods experimental design, the study integrates both quantitative and qualitative evidence to provide a more holistic understanding of candidate reactions. Finally, it offers one of the first empirical insights into how the use of AI-led technologies in interviews affects candidates' experiences in an emerging digital economy.

Building on this rationale, the present study employs an experimental mixed-methods design to examine how FTF, SVI, and AI-led AVI formats influence interview anxiety and performance among emerging adults in a Turkish-speaking context. By integrating quantitative data on self-rated (subjective) and observer-rated (objective) performance with qualitative insights into candidate experience, the study aims to offer a nuanced understanding of how interview modality shapes applicant outcomes in contemporary selection processes. Specifically, the study seeks to identify how interview type influences candidates' anxiety and performance and whether the format moderates the relationship between these variables.

Theoretical Perspectives on Interview Formats

Theoretical approaches developed to evaluate the appropriateness of different communication mediums are crucial for understanding how technology-mediated interactions can affect candidate perception and attitude. One relevant theory is the "media richness theory" which focuses on a communication medium's ability to generate multiple communication cues (Daft & Lengel, 1986). A richer medium produces higher-quality information and facilitates information transmission. According to this theory, different communication media can reduce message ambiguity, thereby decreasing uncertainty among communication partners. For instance, compared to AI-led AVIs, SVIs provide a richer environment by using visual and auditory channels to convey higher-quality information and reduce uncertainty. However, SVIs also lack the physical cues in FTF interactions (McColl & Michelotti, 2019).

The social presence theory (Short et al., 1976) argues that the media channel influences the perception of each other's presence among communication partners (e.g., facial expressions, posture, and tone of voice) (Calefato & Lanubile, 2010). For example, FTF and SVIs have higher social presence than AI-led AVIs, and media with higher social presence are more effective for interpersonal communication. Building upon the media richness theory and social presence theory, Potosky (2008) constructs a conceptual framework and defines four key characteristics of technology-mediated communication: Social bandwidth, interaction, transparency, and surveillance. Social bandwidth refers to the degree to which the media environment allows verbal and non-verbal information exchange. Due to the unilateral nature of AI-led AVIs and the lack of real-time interaction, they have limited social bandwidth as they do not allow for verbal and non-verbal cues and emotional reactions of the interviewer. Interaction focuses on the level of participation in communication and the opportunities provided for feedback. AI-led AVIs are disadvantaged compared to SVIs and FTFs because they do not provide instant feedback. Transparency measures the extent to which communication partners can interact seamlessly without focusing on the features of the environment. Particularly in AI-led AVI, candidates are constantly aware of the technology mediating the communication, resulting in lower transparency (Basch et al., 2021). Surveillance refers to the perception that a third party is observing the candidate during the interview. Candidates are more likely to feel under surveillance in AI-led AVI as they are recording their responses, with the possibility that different individuals may later review them.

Finally, according to signaling theory, in the absence of institutional transparency, individuals infer signals from the available concrete information (Chapman et al., 2003). AI-led AVIs are relatively new in selection interviews, and companies often do not provide extensive explanations to candidates about the process of leveraging AI (e.g., scoring algorithms). This may lead candidates to signal based on their existing limited information. For example, candidates may attribute the use of algorithms to organizations' lack of communication (Acikgoz et al., 2020).

Taken together, these perspectives suggest that interview formats differ in the degree to which anxiety cues become salient and consequential for performance. Formats with higher social presence and immediacy (e.g., face-to-face) may amplify the visibility of anxiety-related behaviors, whereas lower-immediacy formats (e.g., AI-led AVIs) may afford candidates greater opportunity to regulate or mask such cues.

Interview Anxiety and Interview Performance

As emphasized by Lin-Stephens and Manuguerra (2023, p. 5), interview anxiety is a fundamental determinant of interview performance. Although interview anxiety is a common experience for most candidates, research suggests its harmful impact on actual performance, with anxious individuals less likely to secure job offers (Powell et al., 2018). Indicators of anxiety during interviews include disruptions in speech fluency, socially inappropriate behaviors, and physical signs of nervousness (Levine & Feldman, 2002). These manifestations may lead interviewers to perceive candidates as less reliable, task-oriented, and suitable for the job (Ayres et al., 1998). Consequently, candidates experiencing anxiety during interviews often receive lower performance scores and have reduced chances of being hired (Powell et al., 2018). Similarly, anxiety correlates negatively with second interview invitations (Cook et al., 2000), while communication apprehension diminishes the number of job offers candidates receive (Ayres & Crosby, 1995). A recent meta-analysis reported a moderate negative effect (ρ = −0.19) between interview anxiety and performance (Powell et al., 2018), which is evident not only in traditional FTF interviews but also in AI interviews. McCarthy et al. (2021) analyzed 8,343 candidates in a real AI job interview, providing evidence of a negative relationship between interview anxiety and performance (γ = −0.03, p = 0.01).

Overall, this body of work suggests a robust negative association between interview-specific anxiety and performance evaluations. Based on this literature, we developed the following hypotheses:

H1a. Higher interview anxiety is associated with lower self-rated interview performance.

H1b. Higher interview anxiety is associated with lower observer-rated interview performance.

Candidate Performance across Interview Formats

The impact of candidates' reactions on outcomes is significant, even in traditional face-to-face interviews, and the transition of interviews to online environments further complicates matters. The technological nature of SVIs and AI-led AVIs distinguishes them significantly from traditional face-to-face interviews, making it challenging to generalize findings from one format to another. A comprehensive meta-analysis conducted by Blacksmith et al. (2016) revealed that candidates tend to achieve higher performance ratings in face-to-face interviews compared to technology-mediated interviews. However, the studies included in the meta-analysis are nearly two decades old, suggesting the potential for the findings to be outdated in the current landscape of interview methodologies and technologies. As people become more accustomed to interacting in digital environments, such findings may quickly lose their relevance (Woods et al., 2019).

In a more recent study, Melchers et al. (2021) demonstrated that performance evaluations in SVIs surpass those in face-to-face interviews. Contrary to expectations, Langer et al. (2017) found in a study comparing SVIs and AVIs that participants in AVIs received higher performance ratings. The authors suggested that this finding might be associated with the preparation time provided to candidates in the AVI condition. Similarly, Suen et al. (2019) found, similar to the conditions of our study, in a comparison of AI-led AVIs with SVIs and FTF, that performance ratings were lower in the AI-led AVI condition. However, information on how the type of interview affects performance evaluation remains limited and does not allow for a comprehensive conclusion. Based on the literature findings, our hypothesis is as follows:

H2a. Self-rated (subjective) performance evaluations will differ across interview formats (FTF, SVI, and AI-led AVI), with performance expected to be highest in FTF and lowest in AI-led AVI.

H2b. Observer-rated (objective) performance evaluations will differ across interview formats (FTF, SVI, and AI-led AVI), with performance expected to be highest in FTF and lowest in AI-led AVI.

Candidate Anxiety Across Interview Formats

As mentioned, job interviews frequently induce anxiety in candidates, a phenomenon intensified by the diversification of interview environments and the distinct demands of technological applications. From the candidates' perspective, the growing prevalence of SVIs can elicit varying degrees of anxiety. For instance, some candidates may experience heightened anxiety levels during SVIs (Van Iddekinge et al., 2006). Concerns related to aspects of the digital environment (e.g., maintaining a professional background during recording), technical glitches (e.g., poor internet connectivity), and digital communication-related anxiety (e.g., uncertainty about where to direct attention on the screen) may arise (Constantin et al., 2021). Moreover, factors such as candidates' familiarity with web cameras in video interview assessments can mitigate anxiety (Toldi, 2011).

Data collected from AI-led AVI yield qualitative results akin to those from traditional face-to-face interviews. However, the absence of a live interviewer precludes candidates from direct engagement, questioning, or receiving non-verbal cues and feedback (Langer et al., 2020). Lukacik et al. (2022) observed that due to the novelty of this technology, candidates are more susceptible to communication anxiety than face-to-face interviews. Meija and Torres (2018) noted that recruitment professionals generally perceived unmanned video interviews positively; however, candidates grappled with adapting to this new method largely stemming from anxiety, technical obstacles, and disparate hardware and software requirements.

In one of the few studies examining technology-mediated interviews from the perspective of candidate anxiety (Melchers et al., 2021), no significant difference was found in interview anxiety between FTF and SVIs. Balcerak and Wozniak (2021) found that candidate anxiety did not significantly influence the acceptance of SVIs. Furthermore, Ore and Sposato (2022) suggested that asynchronous interviews could enhance the candidate experience by accelerating selection and feedback procedures. In a recent study, Köchling et al. (2023) indicated that artificial intelligence interviews heightened the sensation of "emotional creepiness" including anxiety. Anxiety arises from heightened sensory input demanding attention and uncertainty regarding the most appropriate course of action in unfamiliar circumstances (Hirsh et al., 2012). Interviews inherently involve social evaluation, and candidates often confront the prospect of rejection. However, as FTF interviews have long been commonplace, behavioral expectations and social norms are relatively established. Given the ambiguity surrounding AI and its societal role, candidates may be predisposed to greater anxiety in AI-led AVIs (Mirowska & Mesnet, 2022). Unfortunately, research on candidates' reactions to AI-led AVIs is nascent, and practitioners remain uncertain about enhancing the candidate experience in technology-mediated interviews.

Collectively, these studies suggest that interview modality can shape candidates' anxiety, yet the findings are mixed and often based on earlier generations of technology. Building on this literature, we expected format-related differences in interview-specific anxiety and its dimensions:

H3a. Candidates' communication anxiety levels differ across interview formats, increasing from FTF to SVI and AI-led AVI.

H3b. Candidates' social appearance anxiety levels will differ across interview formats, increasing from FTF to SVI and AI-led AVI.

H3c. Candidates' performance anxiety levels will differ across interview formats, increasing from FTF to SVI and AI-led AVI.

H3d. Candidates' behavioral anxiety levels will differ across interview formats, increasing from FTF to SVI and AI-led AVI.

Overall, the theoretical lenses and prior evidence converge on the idea that each interview format affords a distinct communicative environment—varying in immediacy, feedback, cue richness, and perceived evaluation—which can meaningfully influence candidates' emotional states and behavioral expressions. However, existing studies remain fragmented, often limited to Western samples, and rarely examine the joint effects of anxiety, performance, and interview format within a single integrative framework. Building on these theoretical models, the present study aims to test how interview modality conditions both the experience (anxiety) and outcome (performance) dimensions of candidate reactions in a Turkish context.

To address these gaps, the present study employs a mixed-methods, lab-based design to simulate real-world interviews and assess how FTF, SVI, and AI-led AVI formats influence candidate outcomes. Specifically, we quantitatively examine *(1)* candidates' interview-specific anxiety levels, *(2)* self-rated and observer-rated performance, and *(3)* the moderating role of interview type in the anxiety–performance relationship. In addition, we qualitatively explore participants' subjective experiences to gain a deeper understanding of how they perceive and emotionally respond to different interview formats.

Beyond mean-level differences, the theoretical perspectives reviewed above also imply that interview modality may condition how strongly anxiety translates into performance deficits. Rich, high-presence formats such as FTF are likely to make behavioral signs of anxiety more salient and performance-impairing, whereas lower-presence, technology-mediated formats may attenuate or even neutralize this link. Accordingly, we proposed the following moderation hypotheses:

H4a. Interview format moderates the relationship between communication anxiety and self-rated and observer-rated performance.

H4b. Interview format moderates the relationship between social appearance anxiety and self-rated and observer-rated performance.

H4c. Interview format moderates the relationship between performance anxiety and self-rated and observer-rated performance.

H4d. Interview format moderates the relationship between behavioral anxiety and self-rated and observer-rated performance.

Method

Research Design

This study employs a mixed-method approach, combining quantitative and qualitative research. This approach allows for the systematic integration of both methods within the study, resulting in a comprehensive analysis of the research data. The methodology for each process is detailed in the following sections.

Experimental Design

In the section analyzed using a quantitative method, an experimental approach is used. The independent variable in this study is the type of interview, with experimental conditions comprising 1) artificial intelligence-Led asynchronous video interviews, 2) synchronous video interviews, and 3) face-to-face interviews. Only in the AI-led AVI condition were participants told that an AI system would analyze and score their responses; in FTF and SVI, evaluations were conducted by humans. The dependent variables are 1) the candidate's anxiety level and 2) the candidate's performance. The anxiety level is assessed using the "MASI Scale" (Measure of Anxiety in Selection Interviews, McCarthy & Goffin, 2004), the details of which will be elaborated below. To gauge how candidates evaluate their performance using a valid and reliable scientific instrument, the "Applicant Satisfaction Scale" is employed (self-rated performance). Additionally, two researchers assessed the candidates' performance using the Behaviorally Anchored Rating Scale (BARS) separately (observer-rated performance). The inter-rater reliability score of the observers' performance rating is 0.96.

Since the measurement of anxiety and performance requires an experimental process, a pre-test cannot be administered. In the experimental part of the study, as summarized in quantitative research methodologies, a "post-test only quasi-experimental design" is used (Shaughnessy et al., 2020).

Participants

A call for participation was issued for an interview, which would be rewarded with an internship as part of a thesis project. Interested candidates were provided with a Google Form, which was accessible for 2 months. During this timeframe, 45 individuals applied (11 males, 34 females; M_{age} = 23.06, *SD* = 2.08). The participants' numbers were randomly ordered, and they were assigned to groups through randomization.

A prerequisite for the study was that the participants were not employed in any job. This ensured that the internship reward would simulate the impact of a real job interview. Therefore, the sample consisted of individuals who were either currently studying at universities in Türkiye or not enrolled in university but also not employed in any job. The distribution of participants according to conditions was as follows: For the FTF condition: 5 males, 10 females; M_{age} = 21.8, *SD* = 2.56; for the SVI condition: 3 males, 12 females; M_{age} =22.8, *SD* = 1.93; and for the AI-led AVI condition: 3 males, 12 females; *M* = 22.2, *SD* = 1.72. All participants met the human resources specialist for the first time during the interview, which helped maintain anonymity and ensured a more observer-rated evaluation.

Measures

Anxiety. To measure participants' levels of anxiety, we employed the Measure of Anxiety in Selection Interviews (MASI; McCarthy & Goffin, 2004). The original MASI comprises 30 items; however, certain questions were not relevant to the SVI and AI-led AVI conditions (e.g., "I worry that my handshake will not be correct when I meet a job interviewer"). Consequently, two items were omitted from each condition. Additionally, we modified some statements to ensure that all items specifically addressed the interview context rather than general interview experiences.

The Turkish version of the MASI (MASI-T) (Turgut et al., 2024) revealed a four-factor structure, differing from the original scale. The dimensions of social anxiety and appearance anxiety were combined in the Turkish sample. The MASI-T includes the following dimensions: communication anxiety (e.g., "*During job interviews, I often can't think of a thing to say*"), social appearance anxiety (e.g., *"If I do not look my absolute best in a job interview, I find it very hard to be relaxed"*), performance anxiety (e.g., "During a job interview, I am so troubled by thoughts of failing that my performance is reduced"), and behavioral anxiety (e.g., *"During job interviews, my hands shake"*).

The scale includes a dimension focused on anxiety related to specific aspects of the interview. Communication anxiety encompasses concerns about verbal and nonverbal communication and listening skills. Social appearance anxiety relates to social concerns about one's general appearance, including but not limited to body shape. Performance anxiety involves outcome-related worries. Behavioral anxiety focuses on physical symptoms such as uneasiness and fidgeting.

Participants rated each item on a 5-point Likert scale, ranging from 1 = *strongly disagree* to 5 = *strongly agree*. The Turkish MASI demonstrated strong reliability, with a Cronbach's alpha of .95 for the total scale. The subscale reliabilities were as follows: communication anxiety (α = .81), social appearance anxiety (α = .91), performance anxiety (α = .89), and behavioral anxiety (α = .85).

Performance

Self-Rated Performance. To measure participants' evaluations of their interview experiences, we used The Applicant Satisfaction Scale (Kusku et al., 2003). This scale consists of two dimensions: "Satisfaction with the interviewer" and "self-satisfaction." The authors identified the "self-satisfaction" dimension with two factors, each composed of six items: "satisfaction of preparation" and "Self-expression Satisfaction" (e.g.

"During this interview process, I could not adequately demonstrate my job-related knowledge, skills, and qualifications."

In alignment with the purpose of this study, only the "self-satisfaction" dimension of the Applicant Satisfaction Scale was measured using a valid and reliable measurement tool after the experimental condition. Participants evaluated all items on a 5-point Likert scale ranging from 1=strongly disagree to 5=strongly agree. Sample items from the scale are provided below:

The Cronbach alpha value for the "Satisfaction of Preparation" dimension was found to be at a low rate of. 42. Subsequently, two items (4th and 6th) were removed from the scale, and the analysis was conducted again. As a result, the reliability value of satisfaction of preparation was. 69, the reliability value of self-expression satisfaction was. 63, and the reliability value of the total Applicant Satisfaction Scale was. 76.

Observer-rated performance. In the study, participants in all three conditions were presented with questions determined by a Human Resources Specialist in the same order (for the questions, see Appendix-1). The performance of the participants was evaluated based on the ratings of two researchers. Each question asked during the interview was assessed using a predetermined and fixed 5-point rating scale.

To ensure that all evaluators shared a common reference, descriptive explanations for each rating were provided. These explanations were formulated in a manner similar to the Behaviorally Anchored Rating Scale (Smith & Kendall, 1963), outlining what aspects of the interviewee's behavior should be considered poor, average, or excellent (see Appendix-2). This rubric provided explicit behavioral anchors for each dimension of interview performance (e.g., clarity, relevance, confidence, and nonverbal effectiveness), minimizing subjective interpretation and ensuring consistency across evaluators.

It is important to note that complete blinding of evaluators to experimental conditions was not feasible because the presence or absence of an interviewer in the recording made the format (FTF, SVI, or AI-led AVI) visually identifiable. To mitigate potential bias, the raters were trained to focus exclusively on observable behavioral indicators of performance, regardless of interview format. Both raters independently scored each participant, and their evaluations showed a very high level of agreement (ICC = .96), indicating strong inter-rater reliability and minimal bias. Taken together, the use of a standardized behavioral rubric, independent dual ratings, and high reliability provide confidence in the objectivity of the observer-rated performance measure.

Qualitative Research Method

In addition to the quantitative method described above, a qualitative research method was employed to explore participants' perspectives on the type of interview to which they were randomly assigned. Qualitative research provides detailed insights into complex phenomena, such as perspectives, emotions, and thought processes, which are not readily captured by quantitative methods. At the core of qualitative research is the emphasis on participants describing their experiences in terms that are meaningful to them (Shaughnessy et al., 2020). In this study, participants' perceptions of the type of interview they experienced were examined using a structured interview technique.

Participants

The same sample used in the experimental component also participated in the qualitative phase. That is, the individuals who completed the interviews in the three conditions subsequently provided qualitative data regarding their interview experiences.

Measures

A structured interview protocol was used across all three conditions to ensure standardization and enhance interview validity (Moscoso et al., 2017). The same set of predetermined questions was presented to all candidates in identical order and wording, regardless of interview format. The protocol included introductory questions that allowed participants to describe themselves and their goals, followed by competency-based questions designed to elicit job-relevant behaviors. This standardized structure ensured consistency across candidates and reduced interviewer-related variability.

Procedure

This study aims to investigate the impact of different types of job interviews on participants' levels of anxiety and performance regarding their suitability for an internship program. To achieve this goal, participants were informed that they would have the opportunity to interview for participation in the internship program, with the interview results determining their suitability.

The internship involved a data entry and analysis position at a company specializing in research, education, data collection, and software, located in İzmir, Türkiye. The company's services included statistical analysis, data collection, data entry, transcription, consulting, training, and software development. After consulting with the company's founder, the researchers determined that the most suitable position for an undergraduate intern would be data entry and analysis. As a result, participants were informed that a total of three individuals, one for each condition, would be given the opportunity for a one-month internship at a date consistent with the company-intern agreement.

To maintain neutrality, the specific name of the company was withheld from participants. They were only informed that it was a consulting and training firm and that the internship position would involve data entry and analysis. This approach helped attract candidates whose academic backgrounds aligned with the role, minimizing the likelihood of applicants from unrelated fields, such as medicine. Indeed, all applicants' fields of study were relevant to data analysis.

Ethical approval was obtained from the Izmir Katip Çelebi University Social and Human Sciences Ethics Committee (Document Verification Code: FEE4CD4, Decision No: 2023/04-01, Date: 21.02.2023) before the study commenced.

Participants were required to fill out an online registration form to enroll in the study and were then asked to complete a questionnaire containing demographic information. Subsequently, participants attended face-to-face interviews in the laboratory for the FTF condition, whereas for the SVI and AI-led AVI conditions, interview dates and times were scheduled with the experimenter.

A recruitment specialist with 20 years of experience in human resources led both the FTF and SVI interviews. Each interview was designed to last 25-30 minutes. To enable standardized crossformat observer ratings, all interviews were recorded: SVI and AI-led AVI via their platforms, and FTF via a fixed camera in the laboratory. Following the interviews, the top candidate from each condition was offered a one-month internship.

In the face-to-face interview condition, participants were provided with information about the interview process upon arrival at one of the two rooms separated by a black mirror (the room where records were kept). They were also informed that their interviews would be recorded, and their consent was obtained. During this process, the Human Resources specialist who would conduct the interview was waiting in the other room (the interview room). Once the experimenter completed the procedure, the interview process started.

For the SVI condition, interviews were conducted using Zoom, a video conferencing platform. To minimize technical issues, the experimenter conducted a brief preinterview with each candidate via Zoom 10 minutes before the scheduled interview. The experimenter then exited the Zoom session when the interview started.

In the AI-led AVI condition, participants were presented with interview questions through an application developed by HRPeak, a company specializing in smart video interview systems. Participants received a link via SMS, allowing them to complete the interview at their convenience (For the condition photos, see Appendix 4).

Before participating in the AI-led AVIs, candidates were informed that the evaluation and decision-making processes would be conducted by AI. However, as there is no technology company in Türkiye providing an AI-based decision-making application in Turkish, this was not feasible. Therefore, after the interviews, the participants were debriefed and informed that, for the purpose of the study, they were led to believe that artificial intelligence was responsible for decision-making, even though the actual evaluation was performed by researchers. In summary, participants were initially misled by the accurate information provided at the conclusion of the interviews.

After the interview, the participants were asked to complete a questionnaire. Data for the SVI and AI-led AVI conditions were recorded using computer-based systems, while FTF interviews were recorded in the room with the one-way mirror.

Data Analysis

Quantitative and qualitative data were analyzed within a convergent mixed-method framework. Quantitatively, descriptive statistics, reliability coefficients, and correlation analyses were first computed. Group differences across interview formats (FTF, SVI, AI-led AVI) were examined using a series of one-way ANOVAs. Moderation analyses testing whether interview format altered the link between four anxiety dimensions and performance indicators were conducted using PROCESS Model 1. Observer-rated performance scores were averaged after verifying excellent inter-rater reliability (ICC = .96). All analyses were performed using parametric procedures, as the distributions met normality assumptions.

Qualitative data were examined using thematic analysis following Braun and Clarke's (2006) six-step approach. Transcripts were coded inductively, codes were iteratively refined, and themes were developed through constant comparison across interview formats. A second researcher independently reviewed the coding structure to enhance credibility. Themes were organized to capture shared and format-specific experiences related to perceptions of the interview process, emotional reactions, and perceived advantages and limitations of each modality.

Results

Quantitative Research Findings

Before the analysis, the normality analysis was conducted to determine whether the dataset was suitable for parametric tests. Missing and outlier values were examined. It was observed that none of the participants failed to respond to 5% or more of the scale items. The normality of the distribution was examined using skewness and kurtosis coefficients. Given that the sample size was less than 50, a z-value lower than 1.96 was considered the criterion for normality (Kim, 2013). The results indicate that, for all three groups, the MASI and its sub-dimensions, as well as the Self-Satisfaction dimension and sub-factors of the Applicant Satisfaction Scale, exhibited a normal distribution.

Descriptive Statistics and Correlations Between Variables

Descriptive statistics, correlations, and reliability coefficients are presented in Table 1. Almost all correlations were found to be statistically significant. As expected, interview anxiety showed a significant negative correlation with self-rated performance (r = –.67, p < .001), supporting *H1a*. In contrast, the correlation between interview anxiety and observer-rated performance was non-significant (r = .10, p = .16), leading to no support for *H1b*.

Table 1

Descriptive Statistics and Correlations between the Studied Variables

	M	*SD*	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	9	10
1. MASI[a]	2.20	.67	-	.74**	.72**	.82**	.85**	.77**	-.67**	-.59**	-.57**	.10
2. Communication	2.26	.69		-	.31**	.58**	.59**	.49**	-.76**	-.60**	-.73**	-.16
3. Social-Appearance	2.00	.91			-	.59**	.43**	.42**	-.48**	-.38*	-.46**	.16
4. Social	2.18	.97		.		-	.65**	.44**	-.45**	-.32*	-.47**	.05
5. Performance	2.40	.95					-	.62**	-.49**	-.50**	-.35**	.15
6. Behavioral	2.15	.81						-	-.46**	-.52**	-.29*	.14
7. Applicant satisfaction scale (Self-rated performance)	3.19	.55							-	.88**	.84**	-.14
8. The satisfaction of preparation (Self-rated Performance 1)	2.86	.66								-	.48**	-.02
9. Self-Expression satisfaction (Self-rated performance 2)	3.52	.61									-	-.23
10. Observer-rated performance	23.82	3.85										-
	Cronbach Alpha		.93	.75	.86	.84	.89	.82	.76 [c]	.69[c]	.63	.96[b]

[a]Measure of Anxiety in Selection Interviews, [b]Inter-rater reliability, [c] Items 4 & 6 are deleted for a reasonable reliability score, *: p < .05. **: p < .01

Anxiety and Performance According to the Type of Interview

A series of one-way ANOVAs examined whether anxiety and performance varied across FTF, SVI, and AI-led AVI formats (Table 2). Self-expression satisfaction differed significantly across interview formats, F(2, 42) = 5.44, p = .008, η^2 = .20. Levene's test indicated homogeneity of variances (LF = .615, p > .05). Tukey's HSD test revealed that self-expression satisfaction was significantly higher in SVI compared to AI-led AVI (mean difference = .66, p = .005), whereas no significant differences emerged between FTF and the other formats. Thus, *H2a* was only partially supported, as the full predicted ranking was not observed (see Table 3).

Observer-rated performance did not differ significantly across formats, F(2, 42) = .19, p = .16, providing no support for *H2b*.

None of the four anxiety dimensions differed significantly across interview formats. Communication anxiety did not vary across formats (F(2, 42) = 0.52, p = 0.09; *H3a* not supported). Social appearance anxiety also showed no significant differences (F(2, 42) = 0.34, p = .08; *H3b* not supported). Performance anxiety did not differ by format (F(2, 42) = 0.93, p = .40; H3c not supported). Finally, behavioral anxiety showed no significant variation across formats (F(2, 42) = 0.46, p = .24; *H3d* not supported).

Table 2

Univariate Analysis of Variance (ANOVA) for Anxiety and Performance by Interview Type

Scale	FTF		SVI		AI-led AVI		*F* (2. 42)	*η2*
	M	*SD*	*M*	*SD*	*M*	*SD*		
MASI[a]	2.15	.56	2.25	.84	2.19	.61	.07	
Communication anxiety	2.28	.57	2.11	.77	2.38	.72	.52	
Social-appearance anxiety	1.68	.63	2.06	1.04	2.24	.98	.34	
Performance anxiety	2.60	.87	2.44	1.14	2.17	.81	.93	
Behavioral anxiety	2.01	.80	2.31	.89	2.13	.76	.46	
External evaluators ratings	23.27	4.60	24.13	3.18	24.07	3.84	.19	
Applicant satisfaction scale (Self-ratings)	3.29	.61	3.43	.64	2.85	.56	2.12	
Satisfaction of preparation (Self-ratings 1)	2.90	.90	2.82	1.04	2.35	.80	.15	
Self-expression satisfaction (Self-ratings 2)	3.54	.56	3.84	.53	3.18	.56	5.44**	.20

Table 3

Post-Hoc ANOVA Analysis of Self-Expression Satisfaction and Application Satisfaction Scale on Interview Type

	Group	*n*	*M*	*SD*	Tukey's HSD Comparison FTF	SVI	AI-led AVI
Self-expression satisfaction	FTF	15	3.54	.56	-	.30	.37
	SVI	15	3.84	.53		-	.005**
	AI-led AVI	15	3.18	.56			-

FTF: face-to-face. SVI: synchronous video interview. AVI: asynchronous video interview; *: $p < .05$. **: $p < .01$

Moderation Analysis

Moderation analyses were conducted using PROCESS Model 1, and the full set of coefficients for all anxiety dimensions and both performance types are reported in Table 4. Interview format did not moderate the effect of any anxiety dimension on self-rated performance (all interaction terms were non-significant; $p > .10$; see Table 4).

In contrast, for observer-rated performance, the interview format significantly moderated the effect of behavioral anxiety. As shown in Table 4 and illustrated in Figure 1, behavioral anxiety negatively predicted performance in the FTF condition ($\beta = -2.66$), whereas the relationship was positive in the AI-led AVI condition ($\beta = 1.37$) and non-significant in SVI (interaction $p = 0.0482$).

Thus, *H4d* received partial support, whereas *H4a–H4c* were not supported.

Table 4

Moderation Effects of Interview Format on Anxiety–Performance Relationships

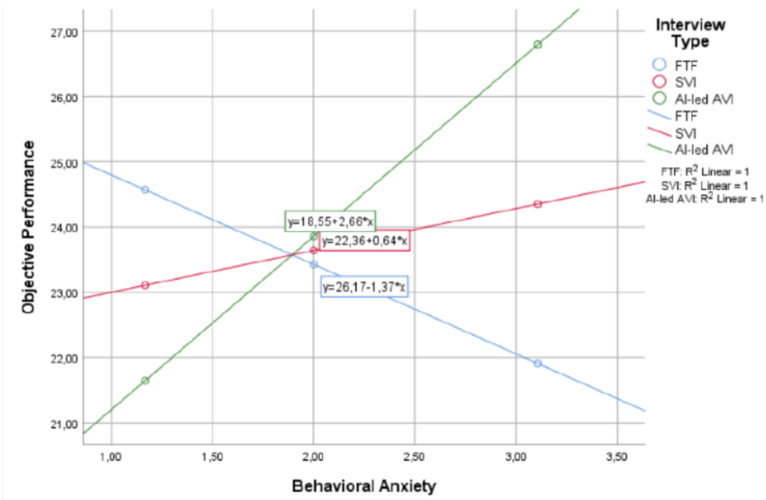
Anxiety Type	Performance Type	Predictor	B	SE	p	LLCI	ULCI
Communication anxiety	Self-rated performance	X	-.77	.37	.04	-1.510	-.0310
		W	.24	.54	.66	-.8526	1.3283
		X×W	-.10	.17	.58	-.4437	.2516
		R^2 change	.00	—	.58	—	—
Communication anxiety	Observer-rated Performance	X	-.10	.06	.12	-.2300	.0280
		W	-.85	.75	.26	-2.3655	.6599
		X×W	.04	.03	.22	-.0243	.1014

Anxiety Type	Performance Type	Predictor	*B*	*SE*	p	LLCI	ULCI
		R^2 change	.04	—	.22	—	—
Social-appearance anxiety	Self-rated performance	X	-.56	.57	.33	-1.7002	.5847
		W	.42	.83	.62	-1.2646	2.1027
		X×W	-.14	.27	.59	-.6812	.3923
		R^2 change	.00	—	.59	—	—
Social-appearance anxiety	Observer-rated performance	X	.02	.08	.84	-.1443	.1773
		W	-.04	.93	.97	-1.9242	1.8473
		X×W	.00	.04	.92	-.0743	.0824
		R^2 change	.00	—	.92	—	—
Performance anxiety	Self-rated performance	X	-1.34	.62	.04	-2.5989	-.0855
		W	-.90	.92	.33	-2.7496	.9545
		X×W	.19	.29	.53	-.4045	.7764
		R^2 change	.00	—	.53	—	—
Performance anxiety	Observer-rated performance	X	-.06	.09	.52	-.2306	.1189
		W	-1.47	1.01	.15	-3.5211	.5775
		X×W	.05	.04	.22	-.0327	.1376
		R^2 change	.03	—	.22	—	—
Behavioral anxiety	Self-rated performance	X	-1.31	.57	.03	-2.4527	-.1646
		W	-.92	.83	.28	-2.6080	.7641
		X×W	.29	.27	.28	-.2469	.8282
		R^2 change	.02	—	.28	—	—
Behavioral anxiety	Observer-rated performance	X	-.11	.07	.14	-.2588	.0386
		W	-1.68	.86	.06	-3.4266	.0613
		X×W	.07	.04	.05*	.0006	.1455
		R^2 change	.09	—	.05*	—	—

Note. The original *p*-value (.0482) was rounded to *.05* to align with the two-decimal reporting format.

Figure 1

Moderation Effect of Interview Type on the Relationship Between Behavioral Anxiety and Observer-rated (objective) Performance



Qualitative Analysis Findings

Participants were assigned to one of three conditions: FTF, SVI, or AI-led AVI. At the end of the interview, each participant answered a set of structured yet open-ended questions related to the type of interview they participated in. The data were analyzed through thematic analysis. Thematic analysis is the process of identifying, analyzing, and reporting themes or patterns in qualitative data. We followed the six-step thematic analysis process proposed by Clarke and Braun (2013): Familiarization with the data, generating initial codes, searching for themes, reviewing themes, defining themes, and reporting. Two researchers independently read and reread the transcripts. In the second stage, we generated initial codes from the text read. Subsequently, we produced initial themes regarding whether the codes could converge under a theme. We evaluated the initial themes during the theme review stage. We separated and re-examined the data for the generated theme and evaluated the fit of the data to the theme. Finally, we identified the “essence” of each theme. We assessed the interaction of subthemes with the main theme and the meaning of the themes and then proceeded to the reporting stage. The interviews were analyzed using the MAXQDA 2020 software.

After completing the six-step thematic analysis process, 138 initial codes were generated, which were then clustered into subthemes and overarching themes based on conceptual similarity and frequency across participants. To enhance transparency, Table 5 provides a comparative summary of the qualitative findings across interview formats. The table synthesizes the key positive and negative aspects, as well as the emotional experiences reported by participants, without presenting individual excerpts or coding layers. This summary reflects the themes derived through the six-step thematic analysis process described earlier.

Table 5

Comparative Summary of Qualitative Findings Across Interview Formats

	Face-to-Face (FTF)	Synchronous Video (SVI)	AI-Led Asynchronous Video (AVI)
Positive themes	Friendly and sincere interviewer attitude; comfortable physical setting.	Supportive interviewer; reduced anxiety via limited body visibility; remote participation convenience.	Absence of interviewer reduces pressure; time for preparation; self-viewing; flexibility in time and location.
Negative themes	Nonverbal cues from interviewer (e.g., facial expressions) increased anxiety; room temperature issues.	Lack of nonverbal cues weakens communication; connection problems.	Lack of feedback; lack of realism; time pressure; self-expression difficulty.
Emotional experience	Anxiety relief, confidence.	Reduced visibility lowers social anxiety.	Reduced stress but diminished sense of reality.

To ensure reliability, two coders independently analyzed the transcripts and discussed discrepancies until full agreement was achieved. Intercoder agreement was calculated as 91%, indicating a high level of consistency in the coding process. This approach increases the credibility of the qualitative findings and demonstrates how participants’ self-rated experiences were systematically integrated into the overall interpretation of results.

Face-to-Face Interview

Participants frequently highlighted the interviewer's attitude as one of the most positive aspects of FTF interviews. Almost all candidates (n = 14) emphasized that a warm, friendly, and sincere approach by the interviewer helped ease their pre-interview anxieties and allowed them to express themselves more comfortably. For example, one participant noted, "*My preinterview anxieties dissipated due to the approach of the interviewer. This enabled me to express myself better. The sincere approach of the interviewer created a comfort zone, allowing us to complete the interview on a healthy basis*" *[P7]*. Similarly, another participant shared, "*The interviewer being well-intentioned and friendly made the interview proceed in a positive and* *comfortable manner*" *[P1].* However, only one participant reported the interviewer's attitude as a negative aspect, stating, "*The facial expressions of the interviewer were disturbing when I struggled with some answers. She seemed dissatisfied with my responses. I involuntarily engaged in mind-reading" [P3].*

Another positive factor frequently highlighted by participants (*n* = 7) was the physical environment of the interview. Many appreciated the privacy, quietness, and favorable conditions of the setting, such as adequate lighting and comfort. One participant remarked, "*The place where the interview occurred was silent and isolated. I did not feel like someone was listening or watching me. The interview was not disrupted in any way" [P5].* Another commented, "*First and foremost, the lighting and comfort of the interview room were reassuring. I felt safe during the interview*" *[P6].* However, only two participants mentioned environmental conditions as a negative aspect. One participant shared, "*The room temperature was high. This caused me to sweat and, to some extent, discomfort.*" Another noted, "*It was hot because the air conditioning was not working" [P8].*

Synchronous Video Interview

One of the key positive aspects of synchronous video interviews, as highlighted by participants, was the interviewer's attitude (*n* = 8). Participants appreciated the interviewer's understanding, patience, and ability to provide clarifications and advice during the process. One participant noted, "*The individual conducting the interview was highly understanding and attentively listened to me without any signs of impatience*" *[P7].* Another shared, "*The approach of the interview panel included providing details to clarify questions, refraining from interrupting the interviewee while speaking, and offering recommendations in areas where the interviewee was observed to excel*" *[P10].*

Another favorable aspect of SVIs was the concealment of anxiety, facilitated by the limited visibility of body language (*n* = 7). Participants appreciated that the reduced focus on physical posture alleviated common concerns associated with face-to-face settings, such as uncertainty about how to position one's hands or body. As one participant described, "*It provided an opportunity to alleviate the anxiety stemming from the uncertainty of where to position my hands, arms, or legs during the initial encounter or when sitting face-to-face*" *[P1].* However, this limited visibility of body language also introduced challenges for some participants (*n* = 4). A recurring concern was that the lack of nonverbal cues hindered the natural flow of interaction and weakened communication. One participant explained, "*The interview I conducted remotely with the person was weak in terms of the necessary conditions for communication, such as gestures and facial expressions" [P12].*

The ability to participate remotely was highly valued by participants, who appreciated the convenience and comfort of attending the interview from home (*n* = 12). As one participant shared, "*The advantage of being able to participate from home was the most important positive feature for me*" *[P6].* However, the remote nature of participation also brought challenges, particularly related to internet connectivity (*n* = 3). Connection problems, such as disruptions or instability, often led to repeated questions and breaks in communication, detracting from the overall experience. As one participant explained, "*At times, there were connection problems, which led to have to repeat the question*" *[P2].*

Asynchronous Video Interview

One of the most frequently discussed aspects of asynchronous video interviews, as reported by participants, was the absence of an interviewer. Many participants viewed this absence as liberating, as it allowed them to express themselves more openly and comfortably without the pressure of being observed (*n* = 4). As one participant shared, "*The absence of another person in front of me made me feel at ease. It felt like I was talking to myself and confiding in myself" [P3].* However, the absence of an interviewer also introduced several challenges. Many participants criticized the absence of feedback (n = 7), which made it difficult to clarify questions, confirm if their responses were understood, or seek additional guidance. One participant noted, "*I had no one to ask for clarification or receive feedback on my answers*." *[P15]* Moreover, the lack of a human presence diminished the realism of the interview (n = 5) for some candidates, creating a sense of emptiness. As one participant explained, "*It didn't feel realistic because there wasn't a person in front of me.*" *[P1]*. Another added, *"As human beings, we naturally prefer engaging in a two-way dialogue*" *[P3]*.

The opportunity for preparation time before responding to questions was widely praised by participants (n = 6). In this study, candidates were given 2 minutes to think before recording their answers, which helped reduce anxiety and enable better preparation. One participant explained, "*The ability to prepare, think, and calm oneself before the video reduces anxiety. It enables a smoother adaptation during the interview process, allowing for more comfortable self-expression. You can plan your sentences*." *[P8]*. However, only one participant perceived this preparation time as a limitation due to its fixed duration. They expressed concerns about the two-minute time constraint, describing it as a source of pressure that led to rushed responses. This participant shared, "*The time given for answering questions felt somewhat short. It pressured me to think hastily, resulting in my inability to express what I wanted to say" [P11].*

Additionally, the ability to self-view during the interview process allowed candidates to monitor and adjust their body language in real-time, which they found beneficial (n = 4). One participant noted, "*Undoubtedly, answering interview questions while seeing oneself has advantages in terms of noticing negative gestures, facial expressions, or body language*." *[P4]*.

Another notable advantage of AI-led AVIs was their flexibility, allowing candidates to participate at their convenience in terms of time and location (n = 13). Participants appreciated the enhanced accessibility this provided, with one participant remarking, "*Both for the interviewers and the interviewees, the practicality of this format, coupled with its enhanced accessibility, constitutes a few of the positive attributes of this interview method*" *[P9]*.

Discussion

The study evaluated the influence of interview type on participants' performance and anxiety. Findings regarding the impact of participants' anxiety on performance indicated that almost all types of anxiety negatively affected self-rated performance. However, observer-rated performance assessments remained unaffected by anxiety.

There is a consensus in the literature regarding the influence of anxiety on interviewer ratings (Ayres et al., 1998; Powell et al., 2018). Candidates, when feeling anxious, fail to demonstrate their true performances, which reflects in interview outcomes (Schneider et al., 2019). However, our findings demonstrated that anxiety did not significantly impact observer-rated assessment scores. Nevertheless, candidates experiencing higher levels of anxiety perceived their performances more negatively. These findings may be attributed to our study, which offered an internship opportunity and elicited less anxiety than a real job interview.

In contrast to anxiety levels, performance evaluations have been extensively discussed in the literature (Basch et al., 2020; Blacksmith et al., 2016; Chapman et al., 2003; Sears et al., 2013; Van Iddekinge et al., 2006). Previous studies have shown that performance evaluations are lower in SVIs and AI-led AVIs compared to FTF interviews. Our findings demonstrated that observer-rated performance evaluations, scored by two external evaluators, did not differ by interview type. This may be due to the fact that the sample consisted of relatively young emerging adults, who are generally more tech-savvy and accustomed to digital communication tools. In line with this, recent evidence suggests that technical hurdles that previously depressed performance in video formats—connection quality, audio issues, and camera-gaze uncertainty—are diminishing in salience as both platforms and users improve (Rigos, 2022).

Additionally, observer-rated performance evaluation was conducted by two external researchers, not by the interviewer. Therefore, the researchers naturally did not consider factors such as the richness of the environment (media richness theory and social bandwidth), perception of social presence (social presence theory), surveillance (perception of being observed by a third party), and transparency (focus on the characteristics of the medium) (Potosky, 2008) when evaluating the interview. These are important factors for both parties involved in the interview experience—the interviewer and the candidate. An outsider, when evaluating the interview, focuses on the verbal and non-verbal responses to interview questions, rather than the variety of cues received and social presence.

Findings related to self-rated performance evaluations indicated that candidates' self-assessments of their performance differed by interview type. In this regard, in AI-led AVIs, candidates' self-expression satisfaction scores were significantly lower than those in SVIs. All participants in our study had no prior experience with artificial intelligence interviews. This lack of prior experience might have led participants to negatively evaluate themselves, as they lacked a basis for comparison even if they performed well. This observation is seen as an indication of the emergence of codes emphasizing negative dimensions associated with AI-led AVIs in our study, such as "reduction of reality" and "lack of feedback". The findings are consistent with the theories proposed in the literature regarding technology-mediated interviews. Candidates in the AI-led AVI condition reported less satisfaction with self-expression compared to SVI. This can be explained within the context of media richness theory, wherein the lack of a rich medium—for instance, the absence of visual cues—creates uncertainty for the candidate, which helps explain why high uncertainty avoidant candidates are more comfortable in SVI than in one-way AVIs (Griswold et al., 2022). Additionally, the absence of feedback in the AI-led AVI condition (Interactivity; Potosky, 2008) and the lack of prior information, such as the assessment scoring criteria of artificial intelligence (signal theory; Chapman et al., 2003), may have reduced candidates' satisfaction with self-expression in the artificial intelligence condition.

Although emerging literature demonstrates the influence of interview type on candidate perceptions and attitudes, it remains unclear how anxiety levels differ according to the interview type. Previous studies have shown that candidates prefer traditional face-to-face interviews less and have a more negative attitude toward technology-mediated interviews (Basch et al., 2020; Basch et al., 2021; Sears et al., 2013). Therefore, we tested the hypothesis that anxiety levels would vary by interview type, with anxiety levels increasing from FTF to SVI and AI-led AVI. Our findings revealed that anxiety levels did not differ among the three interview conditions. Previous studies involving technology-mediated interviews were conducted during a time when technology was not as widespread and robust as it is today. Therefore, the current findings indicating no significant differences among the three conditions reflect the increasing impact of technology on changing attitudes, perceptions, and behaviors of individuals.

The moderating effect of interview type on the relationship between anxiety and performance was observed only for behavioral anxiety in observer-rated performance scores. Further examination indicated that in the FTF condition, performance scores declined as anxiety levels increased, whereas in the AI-led AVI condition, performance scores improved with increasing anxiety.

The media richness theory suggests that communication environments differ in their ability to convey rich information and that richer environments facilitate higher-quality communication. FTF interviews inherently provide rich communication cues and allow for both verbal and nonverbal expressions. This richness enables interviewers to assess candidates' behavioral anxieties through physical cues, such as trembling hands and fidgeting (indicators used to measure behavioral anxiety; see McCarthy et al., 2004). In contrast, AI-led AVIs lack the richness of FTF interactions, limiting the transmission of nonverbal cues and potentially allowing candidates to conceal symptoms of behavioral anxiety. Thus, the varying richness of communication channels affects how anxiety manifests and influences performance.

Similarly, social presence theory emphasizes the perception of presence in communication. FTF and SVIs generally offer higher social presence than AI-led AVIs because they enable real-time interaction and facilitate richer communication. The presence of an interviewer in FTF and SVI environments may increase candidates' awareness of their behavioral anxieties and potentially intensify their impact on performance. However, the decreased social presence in AI-led AVIs may provide candidates with more comfort in managing anxiety symptoms, leading to different effects on performance.

These findings suggest that the moderating effect may be explained by differences in media richness and the way individuals regulate anxiety across distinct social contexts. In face-to-face settings, high social presence amplifies evaluative pressure and the visibility of behavioral anxiety, which can impair performance. In contrast, the reduced immediacy and absence of direct observation in AI-led AVIs may allow candidates to reframe their arousal as task-focused energy rather than social threat, enabling more controlled performance under pressure. This interpretation aligns with arousal-based models of performance (e.g., Yerkes–Dodson Law) and highlights how technology-mediated environments can reshape the functional meaning of anxiety. Future research could experimentally manipulate perceived social presence or feedback immediacy to examine these mechanisms more directly.

In addition to quantitative analyses, the study delved deeply into participants' experiences through structured interviews. Participants in all three conditions listed both the positive and negative aspects of the interviews.

In the FTF interview condition, participants consistently provided more positive evaluations, particularly in their perceptions of the interviewer and the interview environment, with positive assessments significantly outnumbering the negative ones. In face-to-face interviews, it is observed that the interviewer's attitude is important for candidate satisfaction. As previously mentioned, job interviews represent the first real social interaction in which candidates form their initial impression of a potential employer. Therefore, the behavior of the interviewer, to some extent, also reflects the organizational climate in which the candidate would be working if selected for the position. Consequently, participants appreciated the presence of a sincere interviewer. The importance of the interview environment becomes more obvious in such laboratory experiments. While participants were rewarded with the possibility of gaining an internship program because of the interview, they were aware that these interviews were also part of a scientific study. Therefore, participants viewed the inclusion of physical amenities similar to a real job interview in the interview environment as a positive aspect. Furthermore, the emergence of similar subthemes and codes in FTF and SVIs indicated that the two interview methods contained common significant factors in terms of candidate responses.

In contrast, the SVI condition yielded fewer positive evaluations concerning the interviewer, though notably, no negative evaluations were registered. The most favorable aspect of SVIs appeared to revolve around the perceived limitlessness of the physical location, indicating a distinct appeal in this attribute. In the AI-led AVI condition, a departure from traditional FTF interviews was evident, as there was no human interviewer present, and questions were presented visually rather than orally, with allocated time for articulating responses and no feedback provided. Within this context, the absence of an interviewer was positively evaluated by participants, whereas the lack of feedback was viewed as a drawback. However, similar to the SVI condition, participants appreciated the advantage of having time for thinking in the AI-led AVI format. Roulin et al. (2023) could explain why participants with longer thinking times in AI-led AVI conditions received higher performance scores. Furthermore, in AI-led AVI, participants expressed satisfaction with the flexibility of time, another attribute that received positive evaluations. Notably, across all three interview conditions, participants consistently reported more positive evaluations than negative ones in terms of their emotional experiences. These findings suggest a shared trend of generally positive perceptions and experiences among participants, with specific nuances and preferences arising in different interview settings.

Overall, the integration of quantitative and qualitative findings provides a cohesive understanding of candidate experiences across interview formats. The quantitative results revealed patterns in performance and anxiety, while the qualitative analysis contextualized these outcomes through participants' self-rated evaluations. For example, the lower self-expression satisfaction observed in the AI-led AVI condition quantitatively was echoed in participants' narratives emphasizing a "lack of feedback" and "reduction of reality." Similarly, the absence of significant differences in overall anxiety levels across formats aligned with qualitative reports of increasing familiarity and comfort with digital technologies among younger participants. Together, these complementary results highlight how combining quantitative and qualitative evidence strengthens the validity of the conclusions and deepens the understanding of technology-mediated interview experiences.

Beyond the current study, the qualitative findings provide useful directions for future research. Specifically, participants highlighted factors such as the interviewer's supportive behavior, the availability of preparation time, and the presence or absence of feedback as central to shaping their anxiety levels. Future studies with larger and more diverse samples could systematically manipulate these factors to examine their causal role in alleviating interview anxiety. Such designs would not only validate the themes identified in this study but also contribute to developing practical interventions that improve candidate experiences across different interview modalities.

In addition to its applied implications, this study makes theoretical contributions by refining existing models of technology-mediated communication and performance under evaluation pressure. Our findings extend media richness theory and social presence theory by showing that the psychological impact of communication richness and social immediacy depends not only on the medium itself but also on how individuals cognitively reinterpret anxiety across formats. In AI-led AVIs, reduced immediacy appears to transform anxiety from a social threat into task-oriented arousal, partially supporting arousal-based models of performance (e.g., Yerkes–Dodson law) within digital contexts. Furthermore, by examining these dynamics in a Turkish sample, the study adds a cross-cultural perspective to existing Western-centric theories, illustrating how sociocultural factors such as power distance, collectivism, and uncertainty avoidance interact with media characteristics to shape candidate experiences in technology-mediated interviews.

Türkiye's relatively high-power distance and collectivism (Hofstede, 1984) likely increase evaluative pressure in face-to-face settings—making behavioral anxiety more performance-impairing. In high power-distance contexts, people feel less empowered to express themselves or challenge authority (Dai et al., 2022), which heightens interview anxiety. By contrast, the lower immediacy and perceived surveillance in AI-led AVIs reduce the visibility of anxiety cues and enable arousal to be reframed as task-focused energy, aligning with our finding of a more negative anxiety–performance slope in FTF and a weaker—partly reversed for behavioral anxiety—association in AI-led AVI. Conversely, the reduced immediacy and absence of a visible evaluator in AI-led AVIs may have attenuated such effects, allowing candidates to feel less socially constrained. Additionally, collectivist orientations may lead candidates to value interpersonal harmony and social connectedness, making the lack of human interaction in AI-led AVIs less satisfying and potentially reducing self-expression satisfaction. Moreover, Türkiye scores high on uncertainty avoidance, reflecting a preference for structured, predictable interactions (Hofstede, 1984). Aligned with this, prior work shows that higher uncertainty avoidance tends to favor synchronous over asynchronous interviews (Griswold et al., 2022). Accordingly, Turkish candidates may feel less comfortable in the one-way, lower-immediacy AI-led AVI, which fits our finding of lower self-expression satisfaction in AI-led AVI despite no observer-rated performance penalty. Future crosscultural research could systematically compare these dynamics across societies varying in power distance and collectivism to determine how cultural values shape candidate reactions to technology-mediated selection methods.

Strengths and Limitations

This study contributes to the literature in several significant ways. First, the sample consisted of individuals residing in Türkiye. The scarcity of studies examining SVIs and AI-led AVIs from the perspective of candidates in a Turkish-speaking sample makes this research particularly valuable. The geographical and cultural context of the sample, differences in technological infrastructure, technology integration, and participants' technological familiarity, provide unique insights into the phenomena under investigation. Second, in addition to the quantitative findings, the study also included in-depth analyses through structured interviews. This mixed-methods approach allowed for a deeper exploration of the quantitative results via qualitative analysis, enriching the interpretation of the data. Third, the study was conducted as a real interview scenario. Participants in all three conditions were aware that their performance could result in receiving a real reward. This design enhances the ecological validity of the findings, offering an advantage over studies that employ hypothetical or simulated scenarios (e.g., Basch et al., 2020). Lastly, the study's anxiety measures employed a four-factor structure, enabling a detailed analysis of different types of anxiety, including communication anxiety, social appearance anxiety, performance anxiety, and behavioral anxiety. The same multi-faceted approach was applied to performance assessment, incorporating both self-rated and observer-rated evaluations. This nuanced framework provided a more comprehensive understanding of how distinct types of anxiety influence performance across different interview formats, advancing the conceptualization of interview-specific anxiety.

Despite its strengths, this study has certain limitations. A primary limitation concerns the generalizability of the results. While participants were motivated by the opportunity to secure an internship, the stakes of an internship are not as high as those of a job interview. Therefore, it is unclear whether the findings can be directly generalized to actual job interview contexts. In particular, the lower perceived consequences of the internship scenario may have reduced participants' evaluative stress and shaped their anxiety and performance levels differently than in real hiring settings. Although this controlled design enhanced internal validity, it may have limited ecological validity by not fully capturing the pressure and motivation associated with genuine employment decisions. To standardize crossformat observer ratings, all interviews were recorded; in the FTF condition, this involved using a fixed laboratory camera. Because interview recording is uncommon in real hiring contexts, the presence of a camera may have increased candidates' self-awareness or sense of being monitored, which could have influenced their anxiety or performance. Nevertheless, descriptive patterns across formats did not indicate unusually elevated anxiety in the FTF condition. Future research should directly compare recorded and nonrecorded face-to-face interviews to determine whether recording alters candidates' experiences and performance. In addition, the sample was relatively small and demographically unbalanced, making it inappropriate to conduct subgroup analyses based on gender, age, or level of technology use. Such comparisons would not have provided reliable or interpretable results. Future research employing larger and more diverse samples could systematically examine these potential group differences to better understand how demographic and technological familiarity factors influence candidate experiences.

A further limitation concerns the use of researcher-rated performance videos. Although raters could not be fully blinded to the interview format, they were also not blinded to the study hypotheses, which may introduce bias. Using external judges—who would be blind to hypotheses even if they recognize the format—would strengthen the objectivity of future assessments. Future studies should therefore employ independent evaluators to reduce expectancy effects.

Finally, the study's sample size represents a notable limitation. While the design allowed for the examination of the research questions within a controlled framework, research with small sample sizes often faces challenges in detecting subtle but potentially meaningful effects, and this should be considered when interpreting the results.

Conclusion and Recommendations for Policy Implications

Our findings offer several key insights that can influence both recruitment practices and policymaking. Firstly, AI-led AVIs presented unique challenges, particularly heightened communication and social appearance anxiety, stemming from the lack of real-time feedback and reduced social presence. These factors limited candidates' ability to manage impressions and contributed to lower self-expression satisfaction. To address this, AI-led AVI platforms should be designed with features that enhance media richness, such as providing detailed instructions, clear evaluation criteria, and feedback mechanisms, to create a fairer and more supportive candidate experience.

As a middle ground, SVIs offered real-time interaction while maintaining the flexibility of remote participation. However, technical challenges, such as internet disruptions and concerns about virtual presentations, contributed to elevated performance anxiety. Organizations using SVIs should prioritize robust technical infrastructure, clear preinterview guidelines, and accessibility support to reduce these challenges and ensure a seamless process for candidates.

FTF interviews, while providing the richest form of communication and immediate feedback, amplified behavioral anxiety due to the visibility of physical nervousness. Employers conducting FTF interviews should train interviewers to adopt supportive behaviors, such as neutral facial expressions and empathetic communication, to create a more comfortable interview environment.

From a policy perspective, regulations should aim to ensure inclusivity and fairness in recruitment processes, especially as AI and digital technologies increasingly mediate these interactions. Ensuring candidates have access to sufficient preparation resources and educational tools on how to navigate these technology-mediated formats is essential.

Lastly, the study highlights the importance of considering cultural and technological familiarity in designing recruitment methods. For countries like Türkiye, where AI-led AVIs are still novel, capacity-building initiatives could be introduced to familiarize candidates with these technologies, helping to reduce the anxiety stemming from unfamiliarity. National policies that promote digital literacy and ensure equal access to recruitment technologies will be crucial in reducing disparities in job selection outcomes.

In conclusion, while technology-mediated interviews offer significant advantages in efficiency and scalability, their design must prioritize candidate well-being, fairness, and transparency. By addressing the unique challenges of each format and tailoring solutions to local contexts, organizations can optimize recruitment processes while maintaining ethical and inclusive standards.

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Appendix

Interview Questions

1. Can you tell us a little about yourself? (e.g., your education, past experiences)
2. I'd like you to talk a bit about your personal attributes.
    - What are your positive qualities?
    - What are your negative qualities?
3. Can you talk about your hobbies? What do you enjoy doing?
4. What are your future goals?
5. Have you worked on a project? a. If yes, what was your planning and prioritization strategy? b. If no, how would you plan and prioritize?
6. Describe a time when you had to analyze a complex problem or situation. How did you approach the problem, and what steps did you take to reach a solution?
7. The interest in your company's website and social media accounts has decreased in the past few months. As an intern, what steps would you take to improve the company's performance on social media and suggest strategies?
8. You encountered a problem in achieving a goal, and you have a new idea that you need to persuade other colleagues about. What approach would you take?
9. Have you ever encountered a problem that required critical thinking and the development of a creative solution? What steps did you take to assess the problem and find an innovative approach?
10. Things are not going well in your internship, and your motivation has dropped (let's say a new intern started, and there is unequal treatment). How would you motivate yourself?

Behavioral Assessment Scale and Scoring Criteria For Interviews

1. Have you worked on a project?
    a. If yes, what was your planning and prioritization strategy?
    b. If no, how would you plan and prioritize?

	Competency Type: Planning & Prioritization				
	The ability to manage multiple tasks and objectives within a limited time based on the relative importance of each goal in a project, organize resources, create a timeline, and prioritize.				
	1	2	3	4	5
1	There is no clear action plan. Objectives and tasks are not appropriately organized or prioritized. No potential plan proposal was provided.		Objectives and tasks are somehow organized but need improvement. The candidate partially understands planning and prioritization strategies. Some potential plan suggestions were made but lack depth or comprehensive analysis.		A detailed plan has been prepared, taking into account time constraints, prioritization order, and crisis situations. Objectives and tasks are well organized and consistent with overall goals. The plan is rational, creative, and effectively addresses possible difficulties or obstacles.

2. Describe a time when you had to analyze a complex problem or situation. How did you approach the problem, and what steps did you take to reach a solution?

2	**Competency Type: Analytical Thinking & Problem Solving**				
	The ability to analyze complex problems or situations, break them down into smaller components, identify patterns or root causes, think of alternative approaches, and develop effective solutions.				
	1	2	3	4	5
	The approach to the problem is unclear and lacks structure. No steps were taken towards a solution.		Some analysis of the problem was done, but the steps taken to reach a solution are not comprehensive or well-defined.		The problem was deeply analyzed, and a well-structured approach with clear steps to reach a logical and effective solution was followed.

3. The interest in your company's website and social media accounts has decreased in the past few months. As an intern, what steps would you take to improve the company's performance on social media and suggest strategies?

3	**Competency Type: Strategic Thinking and Creativity**				
	The ability to think strategically, anticipate possibilities, and generate innovative ideas to achieve desired outcomes.				
	1	2	3	4	5
	No recommendations or strategies were proposed to improve the company's performance on social media.		Some suggestions were made, but they lack depth and strategic thinking.		Concrete and well-thought-out recommendations and strategies were proposed to enhance the company's performance on social media.

4. You encountered a problem in achieving a goal, and you have a new idea that you need to persuade other colleagues about. What approach would you take?

4	**Competency Type: Persuasion and Influence**				
	The ability to positively persuade and influence others to achieve desired results; effective communication, relationship building, presenting persuasive arguments, addressing objections, and gaining support or participation from colleagues or stakeholders.				
	1	2	3	4	5
	Unable to effectively communicate ideas or persuade others. Lacks the ability to address objections or build rapport.		Some attempts were made to persuade, but communication lacks clarity and effectiveness. Limited ability to address objections or build relationships.		Strong persuasion skills were demonstrated. Clear communication, effective handling of objections, and successful relationship building were achieved.

5. Have you ever encountered a problem that required critical thinking and the development of a creative solution? What steps did you take to assess the problem and find an innovative approach?

5	**Competency Type: Critical Thinking and Creativity**				
	The capacity to critically think and creatively generate solutions for problems; evaluate information objectively, question assumptions, think outside the box, consider multiple perspectives, and propose new and effective solutions.				
	1	2	3	4	5
	Lacks critical thinking skills. No creative approach or innovative ideas were proposed.		Attempted critical thinking but with limited analysis and lacked creative or innovative solutions.		Strong critical thinking skills were demonstrated. Detailed analysis, original and creative approaches, and innovative ideas were proposed

6. Things are not going well in your internship, and your motivation has dropped (let's say a new intern started, and there is unequal treatment). How would you motivate yourself?

	Competency Type: Self-Motivation				
	The ability to stay motivated and determined, maintain a positive attitude, set personal goals, seek opportunities for growth, manage stress, and take proactive steps to stay committed and motivated in your work.				
	1	2	3	4	5
6	Lack of self-motivation is evident. No proactive steps were taken to address the decrease in motivation.		Some awareness of the declining motivation, but limited proactive steps were taken to address it.		Strong proactive steps were taken to address the declining motivation. Demonstrates strong self-awareness and self-motivation skills.

Condition Photos